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The Usurper's Gambit

An Adventure for Fate's Edge Ecktoria

Adventure Overview

Title: The Usurper's Gambit
Region: Ecktoria Marble, Brass, Fire
Theme: Legitimacy, bureaucracy, ritual power, imperial decline
Level: Veteran (Tier III)
Length: 45 Sessions

1 Premise

Ecktoria, heir to the shattered Utaran Empire, stands on the knifeedge of civil conflict. A charismatic pretender has seized the loyalty of the capital militia, silenced dissenting censors, and begun invoking ancient rites to claim the Mandate of Everflame. Meanwhile, the recognized heir King Aldric the Lame clings to legitimacy through law, tradition, and the blessing of the High Temple.

The players navigate a city where every marble colonnade hides a conspiracy, every mosaic conveys a political message, and every oath is engraved in redlacquered tablets guarded by the Censors. They must decide: bolster one claimant, forge a third path, or engineer a peaceful transfer of power in a system designed to resist change violently.

2 Hook

Choose or roll (DV 3 Investigation to determine truth):

tem **The Envoy's Humiliation:** Before the Great Baths of Aurix, the Lame King's Envoy is publicly mocked, their ceremonial staff struck from their hand a grave insult in Ecktoria. The crowd cheers the Pretender's heralds. (Social/Skill challenge, Presence + Command vs DV 4) tem **A Dead Man's Seal:** A courier collapses into the players' arms with a sealed tablet bearing the mark of a supposedlydead claimant. If true, a surviving cousin could upend every faction's plans. (Investigation + Lore vs DV 5) tem **A Contract Invalidated:** A lucrative patronage contract is voided by a Senate Decree half the Senate claims the decree is legal, the other half claims the seals were forged. (Legal investigation, Sway + Lore vs DV 4)

3 Key Factions

3.1 The Lame King's Line

The Lame King's Line tem[Description:] Imperialbureaucratic loyalists adhering to law and tra-

dition tem[Key Members:] High Priest of Everflame, CoinHouse Factors, Veteran StandardBearers tem[Strengths:] Ritualistic power, institutional authority, legal legitimacy tem[Weaknesses:] Slow, cautious, inflexible tem[Methods:] Ceremonial rites, legal procedures, traditional military tem[Position:] Controlled (established authority), Desperate (losing popular support) tem[DV for Alliance:] 4 (mutual benefit), 5 (neutral), 6+ (opposed)

3.2 The Pretender's Cause

The Pretender's Cause tem[Description:] Reformist movement promising "New Augustan Revival" tem[Key Members:] Reformist Senators, Condotta Captains, New Merchants tem[Strengths:] Popular support, military flexibility, economic influence tem[Weaknesses:] Shallow legal standing, reliance on charisma tem[Methods:] Public demonstrations, military action, economic pressure tem[Position:] Dominant (popular momentum), may shift to Controlled under pressure tem[DV for Alliance:] 3 (shared goals), 4 (neutral), 5+ (opposed)

3.3 The Silent Opposition

The Silent Opposition tem[Description:] Reject both claimants, seek provincial autonomy tem[Key Members:] Guild Conspiracies, Shadow Council, Regional Governors tem[Strengths:] Economic sabotage, decentralized structure, patience tem[Weaknesses:] Disunity, lack of public support tem[Methods:] Economic pressure, covert operations, political manipulation tem[Position:] Controlled (hidden influence), may shift based on player actions tem[DV for Alliance:] 4 (shared opposition), 5 (neutral), 6+ (competing interests)

large4 Key NPCs

4.1 King Aldric the Lamé

King Aldric the Lamé tem[Role:] Recognized heir to Ecktoria tem[Age:] 45 tem[Skills:] Command 4, Lore 3, Presence 3 tem[Knowledge:] Imperial law, ceremonial rites, political tradition tem[Motivation:] Preserve legitimate succession and imperial stability tem[Complication:] Physical disability affects public perception tem[Position:] Controlled (legitimate authority), Desperate (losing ground) tem[DV for Persuasion:] 4 (appeal to duty), 5 (neutral), 6 (opposed)

4.2 Duke Logan the Bold

Duke Logan the Bold tem[Role:] Charismatic pretender to the throne tem[Age:] 38 tem[Skills:] Presence 5, Sway 4, Command 3 tem[Knowledge:] Public relations, military rites, popular sentiment tem[Motivation:] Seize power through popular support and reform tem[Complication:] Limited understanding of true imperial traditions tem[Position:] Dominant (popular support), Controlled under legal pressure tem[DV for Manipulation:] 3 (flattery), 4 (neutral), 5+ (opposition)

4.3 Grand Magistrate Valeria Thorne

Grand Magistrate Valeria Thorne tem[Role:] Keeper of imperial law and succession precedents tem[Age:] 52 tem[Skills:] Lore 5, Insight 4, Sway 2 tem[Knowledge:] Every precedent for imperial succession, Pact of Three Flames tem[Motivation:] Preserve legal integrity of imperial system

tem[Complication:] Torn between legal duty and political reality tem[Position:] Controlled (institutional power), Desperate (personal safety) tem[DV for Legal Consultation:] 4 (proper approach), 5 (neutral), 6+ (hostile)

4.4 High Priest Dominicus

High Priest Dominicus tem[Role:] Keeper of the Sacred Brazier and Everflame tem[Age:] 67 tem[Skills:] Arcana 4, Presence 3, Lore 3 tem[Knowledge:] Coronation rites, divine signs, spiritual legitimacy tem[Motivation:] Ensure rightful claimant receives divine blessing tem[Complication:] Torn between stability and renewal tem[Position:] Dominant (religious authority), Controlled under political pressure tem[DV for Spiritual Guidance:] 3 (genuine seeking), 4 (neutral), 5+ (manipulation)

4.5 The Lame King's Envoy

The Lame King's Envoy tem[Role:] Mysterious representative of King Aldric tem[Skills:] Subterfuge 4, Insight 3, Command 2 tem[Knowledge:] Secret negotiations, hidden political moves tem[Motivation:] Advance Aldric's cause through covert means tem[Complication:] Unknown true identity and loyalties tem[Position:] Controlled (operating in shadows), Desperate if exposed tem[DV for Information:] 5 (secrecy), 4 (proper approach), 3 (trusted ally)

5 Key Locations

5.1 The Grand Forum

The Grand Forum tem[Description:] Marble theatre of politics with multilevel balconies tem[Features:] Statues of emperors, mosaic floors, colored awnings tem[Political Significance:] Center of public opinion and political theater tem[Challenges:]

tem Navigating public sentiment (Presence + Sway vs DV 4) tem Interpreting political symbols (Lore + Notice vs DV 3) tem Avoiding public humiliation (Social challenge, DV 5)

tem[Position:] Controlled (normal), may shift based on current political climate

5.2 Imperial Arena

Imperial Arena tem[Description:] Site of trials by ordeal and ceremonial oaths tem[Features:] Underground tunnels, ceremonial spaces, public viewing areas tem[Uses:] Military demonstrations, legal trials, political statements tem[Challenges:]

tem Participating in trials by ordeal (Varies by trial type) tem Navigating underground tunnels (Stealth + Athletics vs DV 4) tem Public performance under pressure (Presence + Command vs DV 5)

tem[Security:] Heavily guarded during public events

5.3 CoinHouse Floor

CoinHouse Floor tem[Description:] Byzantinestyle financial temple with gold seals and clerks tem[Features:] Abacusboards, wax tablets, chanting clerks tem[Power:] Financial control can bankrupt provinces or fund armies tem[Challenges:]

tem Understanding financial records (Lore + Wits vs DV 5) tem Bribing or influencing clerks (Sway vs DV 4) tem Sabotaging ledgers (Tinker + Subterfuge vs DV 6)

tem[Position:] Controlled (legitimate business), Desperate (illegal activity)

5.4 Censor's Hall

Censor's Hall tem[Description:] Labyrinth of documents, shametablets, and censored histories tem[Features:] Red lacquer tablets, genealogical records, censored archives tem[Significance:] Maintains The Line of Fire genealogical record of claimants tem[Challenges:]

tem Finding specific documents (Investigation vs DV 5) tem Deciphering censored texts (Lore vs DV 4) tem Avoiding detection (Stealth + Subterfuge vs DV 5)

tem[Security:] Extremely tight access requires highlevel authorization

5.5 The FireBlessed Basilica

The FireBlessed Basilica tem[Description:] Spiritual heart with gold and lapis dome depicting Everflame tem[Features:] Sacred Brazier, ceremonial spaces, religious artifacts tem[Importance:] Final coronation ritual must occur here tem[Challenges:]

tem Gaining access during blockade (Combat/Skill challenge, DV 5) tem Participating in coronation rites (Varies by role) tem Convincing High Priest (Presence + Sway vs DV 5)

tem[Current Status:] Blockaded by Pretender's forces

6 Adventure Structure

6.1 Act I Cracks in Marble

Opening Scene: Players witness public demonstration of shifting power through one of the hook scenarios.

Key Objectives:

tem Investigate signs of Pretender's growing influence tem Determine if Duke Logan's claim has substance tem Identify key supporters and opponents of each faction tem Begin building relationships with influential NPCs

Sample Encounters:

tem **Statue Alteration Investigation:** Notice and investigate changes to imperial statues. (Investigation + Notice vs DV 4, Controlled/Limited) tem **Militia Patrol Encounter:** Deal with new militia wearing unfamiliar colors. (Social/Combat encounter, DV 4) tem **Political Rumor Gathering:** Collect information from Forum conversations. (Sway + Insight vs DV 3, Dominant/Limited)

Act End: Players discover evidence of systematic effort to legitimize Pretender's claim. Advance Legitimacy Timer +2.

6.2 Act II Shadows in the Censorium

Opening Scene: Grand Magistrate Valeria Thorne is attacked; players must respond.

Key Objectives:

tem Protect or avenge Grand Magistrate Thorne tem Navigate Censor's Hall to uncover truth about succession tem Find or protect the Pact of Three Flames tem Expose forged genealogies or hidden legitimate claimants

Sample Encounters:

tem **Censor's Hall Infiltration:** Sneak through document labyrinth. (Stealth + Investigation vs DV 5, Desperate/Standard) tem **Genealogical Puzzle:** Verify authenticity of claimant lineages. (Lore + Insight vs DV 6, Controlled/Great) tem **Archivist Interrogation:** Extract information from knowledgeable but secretive clerks. (Sway + Insight vs DV 4, Controlled/Standard)

Act End: Players gain crucial legal knowledge about succession. Advance either Lame King's or Pretender's Legal Standing Timer +2.

6.3 Act III Coin, Steel, and Fire

Opening Scene: Pretender's forces blockade the Basilica; crisis point reached.

Key Objectives:

tem Mediate between factions or choose sides tem Sabotage opposing faction's efforts tem Escalate conflict through strategic actions tem Prepare for final confrontation at coronation

Sample Encounters:

tem **CoinHouse Sabotage:** Disrupt financial support for one faction. (Tinker + Subterfuge vs DV 5, Desperate/Standard) tem **Mercantile Leverage:** Negotiate with New Merchants for support. (Sway + Command vs DV 4, Controlled/Great) tem **Basilica Siege:** Break through Pretender's blockade. (Combat/Strategy challenge, DV 6)

Act End: Players position themselves for final act. Advance Coronation Readiness Timer +2.

6.4 Act IV The Coronation of Ash or Glory

Opening Scene: Dawn at the Basilica; final confrontation begins.

Key Objectives:

tem Decide which claimant to support or oppose tem Participate in coronation ritual and Trial of the Everflame tem Deal with consequences of previous choices tem Determine Ecktoria's future political structure

Sample Encounters:

tem **Rhetorical Duel:** Participate in public debate before the people. (Presence + Sway vs DV 5, Desperate/Great) tem **Ritual Combat:** Engage in ceremonial combat under priestly supervision. (Melee + Spirit vs DV 5, Desperate/Great) tem **Miraculous Display:** Create or expose fake divine signs. (Arcana + Subterfuge vs DV 6, Controlled/Great)

Act End: Resolution of succession crisis. All timers culminate in final outcome.

large7 Key Mechanics

7.1 Legitimacy Timer [8]

tem[Advance +1:] Public demonstrations support Pretender tem[Advance +1:] Lame King's supporters lose ground tem[Advance +2:] Key legal documents are compromised tem[Advance +1:] Religious figures declare for Pretender tem[Advance +2:] Military units defect to Pretender tem[When Full:] Pretender achieves effective control of capital

7.2 Legal Standing Timer [6] (Separate for each claimant)

tem[Advance +1:] Genealogical evidence discovered tem[Advance +1:] Precedent found supporting claim tem[Advance +2:] Key legal figure declares support tem[Advance +1:] Ceremonial requirements met tem[When Full:] Claimant achieves legal legitimacy

7.3 Coronation Readiness Timer [6]

tem[Advance +1:] Religious preparations completed tem[Advance +1:] Military support secured tem[Advance +2:] Public opinion shifts decisively tem[Advance +1:] Ceremonial artifacts gathered tem[Advance +1:] Opposing faction neutralized tem[When Full:] Coronation can proceed

7.4 Imperial Favor Track

tem[Exalted:] +2 die to all imperial interactions, access to highest circles tem[Respected:] +1 die to imperial interactions, normal access tem[Neutral:] Standard imperial interactions tem[Suspect:] 1 die to imperial interactions, limited access tem[Enemy:] Hostile reactions, wanted by authorities

large8 Endings

8.1 Aldric Crowned Lawfully

Aldric Crowned Lawfully tem[Conditions:] Lame King's Legal Standing Timer fills first tem[Outcome:] Stable but static Ecktoria that prizes tradition tem[Rewards:]

tem Official positions in imperial bureaucracy tem Access to traditional imperial resources
tem Honor and respect among conservative factions

tem[Consequences:]

tem May become tools of rigid bureaucracy tem Ongoing tension with reformist elements tem
Limited ability to drive significant change

8.2 Logan Claims the Throne

Logan Claims the Throne tem[Conditions:] Pretender's Legal Standing Timer fills first tem[Outcome:] Revitalized but turbulent empire driven by reform tem[Rewards:]

tem Positions in new imperial administration tem Access to military and mercantile resources
tem Opportunity for rapid advancement

tem[Consequences:]

tem Navigate rapid militarization and upheaval tem Deal with foreign ambitions and internal
opposition tem Risk being purged if Logan consolidates power

8.3 A Third Path

A Third Path tem[Conditions:] Players engineer alternative solution tem[Options:]

tem Install hidden legitimate claimant tem Establish Council of Three Flames tem Create regional autonomy under imperial oversight

tem[Rewards:]

tem Key roles in new political structure tem Unique position bridging factions tem Significant influence over Ecktoria's future

tem[Consequences:]

tem Ongoing responsibility for maintaining balance tem Enemies from disappointed factions tem Future adventure hooks across Ecktoria

8.4 Ecktoria Falls

Ecktoria Falls tem[Conditions:] All timers fill without decisive resolution tem[Outcome:] City collapses into street warfare tem[Rewards:]

tem Unchallenged power in local territory tem Freedom to pursue personal agenda tem Reputation as survivor and leader

tem[Consequences:]

tem Destruction of imperial institutions tem Ongoing chaos and instability tem Need to rebuild order from ashes

9 Rewards and Consequences

9.1 Immediate Rewards

tem Imperial Signet Ring: +1 die to bureaucratic interactions tem Ceremonial Blade: Elegant weapon with historical significance tem Red Lacquer Tablet: Document granting special legal privileges tem Merchant's Charter: License for taxfree trade in Ecktoria tem Priest's Blessing: +1 die to religious interactions tem Military Commission: Temporary authority over small unit

9.2 Longterm Consequences

tem **Aldric Victory:** Permanent positions in traditional bureaucracy, conservative allies, reformist enemies tem **Logan Victory:** Roles in new administration, military/mercantile connections, traditionalist opposition tem **Third Path:** Unique political influence, crossfaction relationships, ongoing responsibility for stability tem **Ecktoria's Fall:** Survival skills and local power base, but destroyed traditional institutions and ongoing chaos

10 GM Notes

10.1 Political Complexity

Emphasize the Byzantine nature of Ecktorian politics:

tem Every action has multiple interpretations and consequences tem Legal precedents can be interpreted in conflicting ways tem Public opinion shifts based on ceremonial displays and rhetoric tem Economic power is as important as military force

10.2 Ceremonial Importance

Make ritual and ceremony central to the adventure:

tem Proper titles and protocols matter for social interactions tem Ceremonial objects and locations have real power tem Public performances can shift political momentum tem Religious rites determine ultimate legitimacy

10.3 Bureaucratic Atmosphere

Create a sense of the weight of imperial tradition:

tem Describe marble halls, gold decorations, and ceremonial regalia tem Emphasize the importance of proper documentation and seals tem Show the slow but powerful movement of imperial institutions tem Illustrate the contrast between public grandeur and hidden manipulation

10.4 Player Agency

Provide multiple paths to influence the outcome:

tem Legal approach: Master imperial law and precedent tem Social approach: Manipulate public opinion and personal relationships tem Military approach: Use force to support chosen faction tem Economic approach: Control financial resources and trade tem Religious approach: Influence spiritual legitimacy

10.5 Story Beats

Use the political environment for complications:

tem 1 SB: Minor bureaucratic delay, small legal complication tem 2 SB: Important document goes missing, key NPC becomes suspicious tem 3 SB: Public scandal damages faction, military unit defects tem 4+ SB: Major political upheaval, assassination attempt, ceremonial disaster

10.6 SessionSpecific Guidance

Session 1 Focus: Establish political landscape and hook players into the conflict. Players should understand both claimants have strengths and weaknesses.

Session 2 Focus: Deep dive into legal and archival aspects. Players learn that legitimacy is complex and can be influenced.

Session 3 Focus: Crisis point with Basilica blockade. Players must make strategic choices that affect final outcome.

Session 4 Focus: Climactic resolution and consequences. All previous elements converge in final choices about Ecktoria's future.

10.7 Alternative Endings

If players attempt unconventional solutions:

tem **Popular Uprising:** Players incite general revolt against both claimants tem **Foreign Intervention:** Players invite external power to resolve succession tem **Religious Solution:** Players convince High Priest to reject both claimants tem **Economic Coup:** Players use financial power to force political resolution

10.8 Scaling for Different Tiers

Tier III (Veteran): Standard complexity with significant political and military resources.

Tier IV (Paragon): Add foreign power complications, multiple simultaneous succession crises, and empirewide implications.

Tier V (Mythic): Introduce divine intervention, realityaltering political magic, and consequences that reshape the entire region.